

rust. To reach high performance, teams need to trust each other and share mutual regard where people are supported and respected. There is a willingness to be forthright, open, and free in working with team members. Review the high performing teams page for strategies to build trust.

How to apply the building higher performing teams model: Review the strategies to improve building high performing teams at GitLab. Managers can conduct an assessment with their teams to see if team members trust one another. Use the resources outlined to facilitate a discussion.

A curated list of external resources has also been compiled which may help when adopting this model.

Ask for Feedback

Managers should be open to receiving feedback from their team members. Often there is a barrier as employees feel uncomfortable sharing constructive feedback, let alone with their manager. But if managers are open to feedback, they can slowly grow a culture of feedback within their team, thereby increasing trust. Managers can show their openness by asking for feedback, through 1:1 calls with direct reports or our performance management platform.

How to apply asking for feedback: It may be difficult to ask for feedback from team members as a manager. However, people leaders should be in the habit of regularly asking for feedback. Every 1-1 can be an opportunity for team members to share feedback on your performance. Managers must establish an environment built on trust with no ego to enable team members to be forthcoming.

Overcome Unconscious Bias

As people, we have a natural tendency to make assumptions about others, which means that once someone becomes a manager they might unintentionally favor some team members over others. Unconscious bias contributes to a major loss in trust between managers and employees.

How to apply overcoming unconscious bias: There are a host of free resources available to overcome unconscious bias. Managers and team members should spend time understanding their bias. Take the implicit-association test (IAT) as a first step. Block time on your calendar to take Diversity, Inclusion, and Belonging related training every quarter. Apply empathy to discussions amongst your team and put yourself in others shoes to better understand their perspective.

Take Time Out To Learn

Managers can make it clear that they have a vested stake in team members career development by advocating for their team to take time to learn. Team members look to their managers to provide learning guidance. As a People Leader, send your team interesting articles, thought leadership studies, videos, etc, on the latest trends in your domain. Managers should advocate to take time to learn for reskilling and upskilling on a range of topics relevant to the job. Managers can set an example by fostering a learning culture within the organization by sending a strong message that it is okay to take time out to learn.

How to apply taking time out to learn: People leaders can send a clear message to their teams

by sending them weekly learning exercises to break up the workweek. Try sending out interesting webinars and articles that are relevant to their job family. Encourage team members to take advantage of our tuition reimbursement policy to grow professionally. Managers can also encourage their team to block a portion of their week for focusing on professional development.

"No Work Talk" Team Chats

Managers can set up a more relaxed call with their team that is specifically focused on personally getting to know one another as individuals. It helps to remind us all that at the end of the day, we're people and we have unique hobbies, interests, and milestones happening in our lives! The only rule for this call: no talking about work!

How to apply "no work talk" team chats: People leaders can set up a calendar invite (with all team members marked as optional) weekly or at a desired cadence. Encourage team members to join and get to know each other better in a remote environment. Come prepared with some possible ice breakers if the conversation doesn't immediately flow. An easy one: what are your plans for the weekend? Timezones can be tricky, so if your team is represented globally and it's not possible to schedule a single time for all team members to join, it is recommended to rotate the time weekly so that everyone can be included.

Host a "Lunch & Learn"

"Lunch & Learns" can serve as an opportunity for individual team members to drive training of the team on more complex functions. It doesn't have to be lunch for everyone; you can replace "lunch" with "breakfast," "dinner," or "snack" as teams are geographically and time zone diverse at GitLab. Allowing team members to "drive" the topic can help understand how they function and how their minds work. By enabling team members to support group activities, teams can see individual communication styles, and managers can understand where additional support may be needed. Having a clear understanding of learning styles can help team members and managers support individual and group needs.

How to apply "lunch & learns": A Manager can have the team pick a topic by quarter, and vote across the team, or a subject can be volunteered. For example, an accounting manager's team selected: complex deal types, ramped deals, and reseller billing as topics. Then have one or a few team members work to build the presentation and schedule the "lunch & learn" for the whole team. Ensure there is enough time for Q&A. They are a great way to understand what data we need to review, how we can present information in a meaningful way to learn, and helping the team recognize where their are knowledge gaps.

Managers Enable Team Members to Make Decisions

Managers play a unique role at GitLab. When a team member on their team excels in their role, they should be given an opportunity to make decisions. Allowing team members to play a role in decision-making can enable trust by catering to the team members' skills and attributes.

Host a Team Day

Organized team days, like this example from the Growth team encourage trust and community building. If your team distributed across multiple time zones, enable async participation or have synchronous events across multiple time zones.

Below are potential team day activities:

1. Host a non-work related call, like a social hour or a time to share passion projects.
1. Give a tour to your team of your home town, your favorite place, or a dream vacation spot. Try sharing photos, Google Maps tours, and videos.
1. Play a Zoom pictictionary/drawing guessing game. Try using the tool Drawasaurus.
1. Host live or recorded Zoom classes based on team members skills, like cooking, crafts, fitness, or woodworking.
1. Organize a Walk and talk social chat, a team 5k walk or run, or some other kind challenge to get your body moving.
1. Create Slack social threads to solve riddles, play a trivia game, post GIFs to represent your day, and share photos.

More Ideas for Activities

- Among Us - Free on mobile, multiple platforms.
- Card & board game "table" - Free!
- City Guesser - Free!
- Drawasaurus - Free!
- Drawphone - Free!
- Escape rooms - Small fee based on team size.
- GeoGuessr - Free. Guess your location based on what you see in Google Street View.
- Google Feud - Free. Like Family Feud but you're guessing Google autocomplete.
- Jackbox - Small fee for each pack. Only the host needs to own the game.
- Online multiplayer jigsaw puzzles (1, 2) - Free!

Summary

Building trust takes time and energy. These are not the only strategies teams can apply to build trust but it is a start. Use this page as a guide to building a cohesive and collaborative team. Trust among teammates is the foundation of almost everything we do at GitLab.

SECTION: leadership/coaching.md

Coaching at GitLab

At GitLab, we use coaching to:

1. Provide opportunity for self reflection, communication and feedback
1. Equip team members with skills they need to deliver results for customers
1. Create space to practice strategies for achieving high performance

Coaching conversations are fluid, dynamic acts of co-creation where the coach and the coachee are equal partners. People leaders and individual contributors alike use coaching at GitLab during our 360 review process, giving and receiving feedback, throughout stages of career development, and more.

Why you might need or want a coach

It's a common misconception that coaches are a last resort resource, or only for team members who are on a performance improvement plan. It's also a misconception that coaching is only for senior leaders.

Review examples of why you might want to, or benefit from, meeting with a professional coach. This list is not exhaustive.

1. A people manager is developing their own coaching skill and style to build accountability on their team.
1. A leader wants to add transparency and efficiency to their quarterly planning process, but isn't sure where to start.
1. An individual contributor wants to define their personal leadership style and plan for career growth opportunities.
1. A team member wants to improve their communication style with a focus giving on open and honest feedback.
1. A team member needs guidance in building a system to prioritize their work based on urgency and results.

Selecting a coach

There are various ways to find a coach at GitLab:

mermaid
graph TD

```
A(I'm looking for a external coach focused on...) --> B(Career/professional growth)
A --> C(Personal growth)
B --> D(I'm a Job Grade 8+)
B --> O(I'm below a Job Grade 8)
O --> P(Modern Health)
D --> F(Coaching Right Now)
C --> J(Modern Health)
```

| Coaching Type | Description |

| ---- | ----- |

| Coaching Right Now | Professional coaching by external coaches is offered for managers and IC's Job Grade 8 and above using the Growth and Development Fund. We work with Coaching Right Now as our vendor of choice to pair team members with coaches who have been reviewed by the GitLab L&D team. More information about this program with Coaching Right Now can be found [here](#).

|

| Modern Health | Using our Modern Health Employee Assistance Program provides professional coaching to all team members. Coaches on Modern Health specialize in professional/career, mental health, and financial coaching. |

| Manager Coaching | Your manager can be a coach that steers you towards future goals. Ensure that your Manager can take you on in a coaching capacity. However, coaching can also be a type of interaction you have with your Manager during 1:1 discussions. |

| Internal Coach | Consider a senior to you in your larger team or someone outside of your team that has inspired you on the specific areas you are working and developing on. Consider

searching on this list of available mentors. |

| Alternative Professional Coach | If some reason the coaches offered via Coaching Right Now or Modern Health do not fit your needs, team members with a Job Grade 8+ can seek and get approval for alternate external coaches. |

How coaches coach

Coaches help team members focus their attention on the future while recognizing their strengths and areas for development. Coaches help the coachee tap into their potential, identify desired outcomes, and achieve goals.

Key attributes of a coach include:

1. Ask powerful questions to deepen learning or insight.
1. Help your coachee recognize their strengths and untapped potential.
1. Encourage your coachee to move to action on their choices.
1. Hold your coachee accountable for the actions they have committed to.
1. Fully focusing on the coachee.
1. Listen deeply while offering support.

Essential coaching skills

Effective coaches use a defined set of skills to enable coaching conversations. Those skills include:

{{% details summary="Question" %}}

Asking powerful, open-ended questions. Coaching is about coming from a place of asking, not telling, while empowering team members to create their solutions. Coaching works to "pull out" insight from an individual.

How to structure questions

- Ask open ended questions. Good questions start with "what" or "how." As you move to questions around action, "who" and "when" can also be helpful.
- One question at a time. Focus attention on one question that focuses on one element of the conversation.
- Keep the questions brief.
- Stay with the coachee's agenda. Pick a question that reflects where they are, not where you think they should be.
- Ask for permission. If you want to challenge the person, or give them a suggestion or insight they may not otherwise have, ask them for permission.

Questioning - What to avoid

- Avoid closed questions - they can close down thinking. Avoid questions that use the following: "Does that...do you...have you...is there?"
- Why questions - these can cause the person to feel defensive and may close down their learning from the coach.
- Leading questions, statements, or opinions in the form of questions. These points the coachee to a place you think they should go, when they will be more committed to action if they come to

their own conclusions.

- Stale questions - avoid asking questions that you thought of at the start of the session, but which may not be relevant anymore (If you find yourself waiting for the right time to ask a question, chances are you may not be listening anymore).

{{% /details %}}

{{% details summary="Listen" %}}

Listening enables openness and curiosity. It also signals to the coachee that you are fully present. To ask great questions, you need to be fully listening.

Listening like a coach

- Be present physically, mentally, emotionally (close down screens and give your coachee your undivided attention).
- Focus on the other coachee.
- Listen with curiosity and without judgment.
- Allow time for silence when the coachee is processing your question.
- Pay attention to body language through video chat: Make eye contact in the camera, smile, make gestures such as nodding your head to show you are present and lean into the discussion.
- Provide focus and try to clarify for the coachee.
- Without judgement, offer an observation, hold up the mirror to show what you are hearing and to deepen insight for the other person.
- Without judgement, confront or challenge what might be a limiting belief to open up new opportunities for the coachee.

What to listen for

- The tone of voice
- The pace of speech and shifts in energy
- Virtual body language
- Choice of words
- Overarching themes or what the coachee continues to come back too
- Underlying beliefs and assumptions
- Blind spots
- Personal values and what matters most to them
- The pauses and the silence

{{% /details %}}

{{% details summary="Encourage" %}}

Encourage and show enthusiasm by identifying strengths in the coachee to build trust. Be open and ground yourself in individual team member strengths. Reflect on what you noticed and determine the impact on the coachee to see that the feedback has landed.

When to Encourage

- At the beginning of a coaching conversation, acknowledge progress made or an accomplishment achieved.
- During a conversation, acknowledge when the coachee makes a connection or gains new insight.
- During brainstorming, acknowledge when someone has stretched beyond their comfort zone.

- During planning for action, acknowledge someone's commitment to change.

Strategies to practice encouraging

- Acknowledging: Focuses on the coachee - who they are as a person and what they have done in their life, their inner character. Make the coachee feel unique and that you recognize what sets them apart.
 - Appreciating: Focuses on the positive impact and contribution of the deed to others.
 - Praising: Focuses on the deed, what people do - results, transparency, efficiency, inclusion, and performance.
- {{% /details %}}

{{% details summary="Challenge" %}}

Challenge your coachee to push their comfort zone, raise the bar, and play a bigger role. Your role as a coach is to hold a bigger picture of what's possible. A great challenge jolts someone into examining the limits of their comfort zone and move beyond them.

When to challenge

- When your coachee has been sitting in their comfort zone or they've been playing it safe for too long.
 - A coachee who has been moving fast and thrives on challenges.
 - To increase the coachee's self-confidence and to increase their perception of what is possible.
- {{% /details %}}

{{% details summary="Be Present" %}}

Focus on the other person without judgment. Give your coachee your undivided attention. Closeout other programs during a virtual coaching session. Be open and curious by identifying what's working and what's not. Be truly present physically, mentally, and emotionally.

Strategies on how to be present

- Make gestures such as nodding your head to show you are present.
 - Empty your own mind of all preoccupations that are diverting your own focus, attention, and energy.
 - Ground yourself in an open, curious, and appreciative mindset.
 - Look for something to appreciate about your coachee, your self, and the coaching process.
 - Ground yourself in your intentions for the coaching conversation.
- {{% /details %}}

Different hats for different conversations

Coaching is just one mode of conversation you might use as a leader. You may be a team lead running an engineering program. You may be managing one of our TMRG's. You may be a mentor or an onboarding buddy. You are also most likely a direct report of someone else. Think of these roles as wearing different hats.

You may wear multiple hats in any given day:

1. Manager Hat - Being directive and assigning tasks to your team.
1. Teacher Hat - Passing on your knowledge and expertise to grow someone else's skills.
1. Mentor Hat - Sharing advice and giving guidance from your own experience.
1. Coach Hat - Asking questions and listening deeply to help team members reach solutions.

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Trust and Coaching

Building trust is an important ingredient in coaching and team dynamics. Trust lies at the heart of a functioning and cohesive team. There are five dysfunctions of a team according to Patrick Lencioni that can break down trust throughout the team:

1. Absence of Trust: Team members are reluctant to be vulnerable with one another and are unwilling to admit their mistakes, weaknesses, or need for help.
1. Fear of Conflict: Lack of trust prevents the flow of unfiltered, passionate debate about tasks, activities, and projects. These conversations are crucial to ensure all voices are heard and all options are considered.
1. Lack of Commitment: Without some conflict it is difficult for team members to commit to decisions, fostering an environment where ambiguity prevails. A team with strong commitment is more likely to put in more effort.
1. Avoidance of Accountability: When teams do not commit to a clear plan of action, even the most focused and driven individuals are hesitant to call their peers on actions and behaviors that may seem counterproductive.
1. Inattention to Results: When no one is accountable, team members may naturally tend to put their own needs ahead of the collective goals; for example, career development and recognition.

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The Trust Equation

The Trust Equation^{™} is a concept to help increase trustworthiness with your team. The more trust you have with team members, the easier it will be to have coaching conversations.

The trust equation uses four objective variables to measure trustworthiness:

Objective Variable Measurement
----- -----
Credibility: My word is believable. Put simply, credibility rates "what you say and how

believable you are to others." In other words, you must be credible if you are asking others to follow your lead. |

| Reliability: | I do what I say I will do. Reliability measures "actions, and how dependable you appear." Can you be counted on? People need to know that their leaders will come through for them. |

| Intimacy: | I empathize with others. Intimacy considers 'how safe people are sharing information with you.' When you are presented with confidential information, you need to keep it so. |

| Self-Orientation: | My focus is on my team, not personal gain. Self-orientation is a personal focus on yourself or others. Too much self-focus will lower your degree of trustworthiness. |

The trust equation has one variable in the denominator (self-orientation) and three in the numerator (credibility, reliability, intimacy). Increasing the value of the factors in the numerator increases the value of trust. Increasing the denominator (self-orientation) decreases the value of trust.

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Neuroscience of Trust

The neuroscience studies show that recognition has the largest effect on trust when it occurs after a goal has been met. The neuroscience of trust can help team members increase empathy, plan efficiently, and decrease threat and fear responses.

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The Return on Trust

Compared with people at low-trust companies, people at high trust companies report the following according to a study from Accenture:

1. 106% more energy at work
1. 76% more engagement
1. 50% higher productivity
1. 60% more satisfaction with their job and 29% more satisfaction with their lives
1. 70% more aligned with their companies purpose
1. 74% less stress
1. 40% less burnout

Additional resources on trust building

1. How to build and rebuilt trust - Ted Talk
1. New to the Team? Here's How to Build Trust (Remotely) - Harvard Business Review

Will and skill

Will and Skill is a framework that can be used to coach team members based on their Will and Skill. Will reflects the team member's motivation and engagement with their work. Skill is a reflection of their ability to do the tasks. Scoring in either category as high or low means a team member will fall into one of four quadrants, each of which can be coached and managed differently.

- Persinio's Guide to Will and Skill Matrix
- AIHR's Guide to Will and Skill
- WhatFix's Blog on Will and Skill
- MindTool's video on Will and Skill
- OMT Global's video on Will and Skill

Managing your inner fixer

To effectively coach, it is critical to manage your inner fixer · Our inner fixer wants desperately to TELL! The role of coach supports people as they develop new habits, explore new ways of engaging, and figure out what they need to do, to be at their best. This approach requires more coaching vs telling. More supporting vs giving directions.

- The Leader as Coach
- Stop Fixing & Start Coaching
- In Coaching: Is Asking The Right Questions More Important Than Having All The Answers?

GROW Model

The GROW Model is a four-step method for holding coaching conversations with a coachee. You can apply it during coaching sessions to guide the coachee through future-focused discussions.

G - Goals: Identify the inspirational goal to drive success and keep energy and motivation high.

R - Reality: Discuss the current situation and what barriers currently exist to achieve future goals

O - Options: Explore the options for moving forward

W - Way Forward: Agree on specific actions and timeframe to set accountability for the coachee

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Attributes of a coachee

As a coach uses their core coaching skills, a coachee can access their own set of skills and activities to get the most out of the coaching conversation through the following:

1. Be Present: Just as the coach is being present, a coachee needs to be present in the conversation, attentive, open to possibilities and fully engaged.
1. Reflect: A coachee is invited to reflect, wonder, ponder, and contemplate through a coaching conversation through powerful questions.
1. Visualize: The coachee can harness the power of their imagination and paint a picture in their mind of the desired future outcomes to enhance their chances of success.
1. Learn: Coaching conversations revolve around learning by discovering new perspectives by coming to a new understanding or realization.
1. Transform: Change is a core attribute of coaching. Sometimes the transformation may be small when a coachee has increased clarity on appropriate action to move forward. At times the transformation may be more profound, as a coachee can shift their mindset in a way that there's no going back.

Coaching Conversations

Planning for action

The planning for the action phase is about enabling the coachee to make a plan with action steps that support their goals.

How to plan for action:

- The coachee commits to and is accountable for actions that they design for themselves.
- The coach may brainstorm, probe, request, challenge, or raise the bar but the coachee is ultimately responsible for designing the action steps.
- The coach's actions for the coachee are in service of the coachee's agenda.
- Coaches may not necessarily be attached to the results a coachee achieves.
- Actions are anchored in what is important to the coachee, what changes they want to achieve. Coaches should hold their coachee accountable for performance on action steps and their overall change agenda.

When you are planning for action while wearing your coaching hat, you are not evaluating or judging or driving your agenda. The coachee should ultimately decide the action steps, committing to their path forward. As a coach, you are curious and non-judgemental while living up to GitLab values.

Sample planning for action questions

- What might be three next steps that you can take in order to....?
- What are you going to do? When are going to do it? How will you know?
- What do you need/want to find more about...?
- What kind of support do you need? From whom?
- My request is that this week you... Will that work for you?

- I challenge you to...What do you think?
- In what way do you want me to follow up with you?

Ending the coaching conversation

When a coaching session is completed, it is essential to review the goal of the conversation with the outcome by asking:

- So you wanted to talk about , in what way has this conversation been useful for you?
- What do you want to take away from this conversation?

The coach might also want to end the conversation with a few statements about what this session has reminded them of and what they truly appreciate in the coachee. Coaching is about empowering. They are helping team members to increase and balance their self-confidence and self-worth:

- What I truly appreciate from our conversation was...
- What I admire you for is...
- What you have helped me realize, learn, or reminded me about is...

Additional coaching skills

- Offering a big picture perspective
- Use of metaphors
- Brainstorming
- Creating a compelling picture of what could be
- Championing
- Challenging
- Identifying underlying limiting beliefs, assumptions, and mindset
- Tips for managing conflict

Team member relations

When coaching is unsuccessful, GitLab's Team Member Relations group is available to help you. The first thing a manager should do is reach out to the aligned Team Member Relations Partner to review the situation and collaborate on a plan of action. That action will include additional coaching, both verbal and documented.

There are times when a Team Member's behavior becomes so egregious that it is more than a performance issue, and becomes a true conduct concern. If at any point you suspect a team member has engaged in such behavior TMR should be looped in immediately, regardless of whether or not you consider the Team Member a high performer.

- TMR Handbook Page
- LDR 102 Underperformance
- Managing Underperformance Handbook Interview

Live Learning Session

During Week 2 of our Manager Challenge Pilot, we had a course covering Building Trust and

Coaching. The slide deck and meeting agenda follow along with the session.

A recording of the first of two sessions can be found here:

{{< youtube "jvjBgC3Bi2s" >}}

Introduction to Coaching

{{< youtube "9qUlp8LrduM" >}}

We held 50 minute Introduction to Coaching Live Learning sessions on 2020-12-03. The recording follows along with the slide deck and agenda.

Coaching Manager Competency

In an all-remote organization, coaching is a critical skill for managers to develop and improve upon as they progress in their careers. Coaching helps to facilitate the career development of team members through regular coaching conversations. Coaching helps team members change behavior, improve performance, and sustain commitment through encouragement, support, collaborative problem-solving, goal setting, and feedback.

Skills and behavior of the coaching competency for managers:

- Facilitates job performance growth of team members by providing regular coaching sessions
- Understands team members long-term career goals and acts as a mentor and guide to achieving them
- Conducts development and career planning dialogues with team members continuously
- Reflects on their leadership style and impact on the team and team situation
- Seeks new coaching approaches and techniques and exemplifies what it means to continuously develop their skills
- Delivers effective strategies for dealing with cases of underperformance and instills that in other leaders across the organization

Additional coaching resources

- The Leader as Coach - Harvard Business Review Article
- What Can Coaches Do for You? - Harvard Business Review Article
- Four Tips for Coaching Remote Employees
- An overview and comparison of coaching models including GROW, CLEAR, and OSCAR
- A 10 minute video on the CLEAR coaching model as an alternative to the GROW model

SECTION: leadership/compensation-review-conversations.md

Compensation Review Conversations

Conversations with regards to compensation are an important part of being a people manager. This page will take you through information and recommendations to effectively manage and guide these conversations. If you're ever in doubt or have a question, don't hesitate to reach out to

your aligned People Business Partner.

For more information for managers on the FY25 Annual Compensation Review Cycle, please refer to the Manager Information Guide

Content to Review Prior to Compensation Conversations

Please make sure to review and understand the following content with regards to Compensation at GitLab:

- GitLab's Guide to Total Rewards
- LevelUp Training: GitLab Total Rewards Compensation Fundamentals
- Compensation Calculator
- Annual Compensation Review Cycle
- Equity Refresh Program
- Talent Assessment at GitLab

Total Compensation Statements

For FY25, Total Rewards will be providing Total Compensation Statements outlining the total compensation increase (cash and equity) and/or promotion received during Annual Compensation Review. We recommend reviewing this letter before the conversation and using the letter as preparation to communicate the compensation decisions and expected total compensation. It is also recommended that you send the letter to the team member after your conversation with them so they can view the details. You can find instructions on how to pull the Total Compensation Statement in the job aid

Compensation Communication Recommendations

- Communicate the increase face-to-face over Zoom. As a manager, this is an opportunity for you to have a conversation with your team member about their compensation, increase and/or equity refresh grant (if applicable). Having the conversation over Zoom allows for you to have a dialogue with your team member (versus just sharing the number) and allows you to pick up other information like tone and non-verbal cues which can tell you more about how someone is feeling.
- Prepare for the call ahead of time. As a manager, you should have awareness of the following facts about GitLab's compensation principles (please review the handbook's Global Compensation page), any recent changes to the compensation calculator/band and personal details about your team member in Workday:
 - Hire date
 - Current compensation (including base salary, variable pay (where applicable), equity etc.)
 - Date of last compensation adjustment
 - Performance Factor
 - Growth Potential Factor
 - Key Talent
 - Location factor changes
 - Benchmark changes
 - % and increase: This number can be found on the Total Compensation Statement
- Communicate the change at the beginning of the meeting. You want to give the team member time to ask questions and discuss their compensation change. Avoid trying to rush to communicate at the end of a 1:1 meeting.

- Try to clearly explain the reasoning behind the compensation change. As Compensation differentials are related to performance, the preparation done for the Talent Assessment conversation could also be useful in explaining the "why". It is also recommended to review the Annual Compensation review page for all considerations that go into compensation reviews.
- Protect the confidentiality of other team members by avoiding saying things like "everyone else received less than you" or "you were the only team member to get a discretionary increase."
- Avoid blaming others (For example: "I would have given you more but management didn't approve.")
- Avoid making future promises (For example: "In the next review, I will get you a large adjustment.")

Compensation Conversations Scenarios

This section provides an overview of potential compensation conversation scenarios with recommendations on how to approach and navigate these conversations.

Compensation

1. Receiving a Cash Compensation Increase:

Sample Script:

- "I am so pleased to inform you that you will be receiving a cash compensation adjustment as a result of this year's compensation review. Your compensation increase is based on one or more of the following factors (Talent Assessment, Location Factor/Geo Region, Benchmark change and/or Discretionary).
- Your salary will be increased to (insert \$ amount in local currency) which is a (insert %) adjustment effective, February 1st.

1. Equity Refresh Grant (if applicable):

Sample Script:

- "I am (also) pleased to inform you that your equity refresh grant is approved at (insert USD). The following factors were considered in determining the equity refresh grant (Talent Assessment, Criticality of Role/Skills, Tenure, Unvested equity holdings). This means your total unvested equity is \$XX based on the share price of \$X (as listed on the Total Compensation Statement)".
- "Thank you for your hard work and I look forward to continuing to work with you! Do you have any questions?"
- Recommended: If identified as Key Talent: "Based on the impact you have on the business/ARR/Product/essential processes and your performance within that responsibility, I (or Senior Leadership) have identified you as Key Talent. This means we feel you fulfill a key role within GitLab and we value your skills and what you deliver to the company."

1. Not receiving an increase or refresh grant: A team member is not receiving an adjustment:

Sample Script:

- Cash Compensation Sample Script:

"As you know, GitLab just went through our Annual Compensation Review. I wanted to inform

you that you are not be receiving a compensation adjustment at this time. This is due to (examples below)...

- A team member is new to the team and at the market range for your aligned role. "You are meeting performance expectations at this time (if applicable), however, we hire new team members at a competitive market rate and considering your recent start at GitLab, we feel that you are compensated accurately for your role at this time compared to peers in the organization.

- A team member is not receiving because they are above range for their role. "Your compensation is above the market pay range for your role and therefore you are not receiving an additional increase as a part of the Annual Compensation Review. You are meeting performance expectations at this time (if applicable), so let's discuss what you want to work on in the future and create a development plan together."

- A team member needs to improve performance. For questions on specific situations, please work with your People Business Partner.

Equity Refresh Sample Scripts:

- A team member was eligible, and was performing at expectations, but is not receiving refresh grant

Not all team members were able to receive refresh grants, despite eligibility, as it is in the program setup/market alignment that we allocate only to a certain portion of our population. Aligned with our expected distribution, typically organizations have ~25% of team members "exceeding", 60-65% "performing", and 10-15% "developing". Core performers make up the most significant population in organizations, meaning that difficult decisions needed to be made in this group in terms of who was granted a refresh and who was not.

These were the factors considered that contributed to the decision to not allocate an additional refresh for you this year:

- Not enough improvement on identified performance/growth areas: "Aligned with our performance discussion in FY23 we have identified improvement areas, such as [EXAMPLES]. Between that review and this equity review, there was not sufficient improvement in the areas identified. Therefore the decision has been made to not grant you additional equity at this time. I would love for us to further discuss those improvement areas and see how I can support you in meeting all expectations going forward. We review equity grants on an annual basis, and I hope we can work together to reassess your eligibility for next cycle."

- Role or skill based decision: "Participation in this program was based on performance and criticality of role/skills. Therefore, not all team members will receive a refresh grant in the annual review cycle. However this is an annual process. You will be eligible to participate in next year's program."

- Not in good standing with the company There could be factors that have contributed to the fact that currently the team member is not in good standing with the company. Examples here could be: Code of conduct violations or significant behavioral issues. As a communicating manager please discuss these with Team Member Relations and your People Business Partner.

- Has been with the company for a shorter period of time: Team members with less than 6 months tenure were not eligible for a refresh based on our eligibility cut off date. However, aligned with the equity refresh program setup and market alignment, not all team members who are eligible based on start date will receive a grant. Tenure has relevance when considering overall impact of contributions so far, demonstrated performance and growth potential, and unvested equity levels. Tenure was a factor in considering grant allocations.

- A team member's New hire equity grant was significant. "You are meeting performance expectations at this time (if applicable), however, with proposing equity refresh grants we

review holdings against hire date and peers for equality. Based on that extensive review, we feel you are well positioned from an equity perspective for your role compared to peers in the organization.

1. Team member was hired after the cut-off date: "At GitLab we review compensation (cash + equity + benefits) on a yearly basis. Due to your hire date you were not eligible to receive additional compensation at this time. You will be eligible for the next Annual Compensation Review where we will review both your cash and equity compensation."

1. Team member is receiving either just a compensation adjustment or just an equity grant
Please refer to the guidance above to explain to a team member why they may be receiving either just a compensation adjustment or just an equity grant.

1. Team member is receiving a (cash compensation increase/equity refresh grant) while on Leave:
Our recommendation is to send this via email to the team members GitLab email address, but team members are not required to respond.

Sample Email:

- "I am so pleased to inform you that you will be receiving a (cash compensation adjustment/equity refresh grant) as a result of this year's compensation review. You will see your compensation increase effective on February 1st. Your (compensation increase/equity refresh grant) is based on one or more the following factors (Talent Assessment, Location Factor/Geo Region, Benchmark change and/or Discretionary).

Details of this will be outlined on the Annual Compensation Statement attached.

- Your salary will be increased to (insert \$ amount in local currency) which is a (insert %) adjustment (and/or)

- I am (also) pleased to inform you that your equity refresh grant is approved at (insert USD). This means your total unvested equity is \$XX based on the share price of \$X (as listed on the Total Compensation Statement)".

Thank you for your ongoing commitment to results at GitLab! If you have any questions you can reach out, otherwise this email is for your information only and no reply is required."

1. Other scenarios: If you have a scenario different from the above, and/or you need help with messaging, please work with your manager or People Business Partner.

- Although informing a team member that they are not getting a compensation adjustment and/or equity grant is a tough message to deliver, managers should have this direct conversation. This is directly aligned with our transparency value. We want everyone to know why they may not have received an adjustment and give them the space to ask questions.

Possible Reactions

1. A team member is not happy with their compensation adjustment (cash and/or equity).

- Listen to your team member's feedback and allow them to express their concerns.

- Ask open ended questions to allow for the team member to share more (like what were your expectations for an adjustment this year? Why were those your expectations?)

- Reiterate GitLab's compensation philosophy. We pay to market based on the compensation calculator and increase compensation annually based on performance.

- Point your team member to the Compensation Calculator where they can see the range for their role.

- If your team member is in good standing from a performance perspective, work with them to put together a development plan to help them achieve their goals (e.g. skill development or a promotion).

1. A team member is not happy with their performance and/or growth potential rating.
 - Listen to your team member's feedback and allow them to express their concerns.
 - Refer back to the conversation you had with your team member at the time performance/growth potential ratings were determined and reiterate the justification and feedback that you provided at that time.
 - If your team member is in good standing from a performance perspective, work with them to put together a development plan to help them continue to grow.

If you need assistance after reviewing the handbook, please work directly with your manager or your People Business Partner

SECTION: leadership/crucial-conversations.md

Any synchronous or asynchronous engagement with team members may turn into a crucial conversation. At GitLab, we can develop the skills of sensing the tone of an async or sync conversation to uncover potential pain-points, risks, blockers, etc for team members. We need to find a way to create psychological safety for our people. Using a 1-1 can be a great way to gain context on a situation a team member is facing and hold a crucial conversation.

What is a Crucial Conversation: According to the book, a conversation to be crucial is that the results of it could have a huge impact on the quality of your life. A conversation involving a promotion, performance, debate between coworkers, etc. In short crucial conversations are discussions between two or more people where:

1. Stakes are high
1. Opinion vary
1. Emotions run strong

Most of us are good at avoiding them because it's human nature to avoid pain and discomfort when addressing a crucial conversation. So what do you do when faced with a crucial conversation?

1. We can avoid them
1. We can face them and handle them poorly
1. We can face them and handle them well

At GitLab, there can be many instances where a crucial conversation is needed. Whether it is addressing the underperformance of a team member, discussing the results of promotion, interviewing, being notified that a high performer is leaving the team, etc. The Crucial Conversations book has strategies laid out that can help master one:

1. Power of Dialogue: Gaining information and context on the situation. The free flow of meaning between two or more people.
1. Shared Meaning: Each of us enters conversations with our own opinions, feelings, theories, and experiences about the topic at hand. Coming to a shared opinion and entering a pool of a shared meaning helps our synergy with team members in many ways. Adding information to the shared pool of meaning requires each person to take meaningful ownership of their role in the conversation.

1. Start with the Heart: If you can't get yourself right, you'll have a hard time getting dialogue right by looking inward first. Apply empathy in the moment by asking questions to yourself that return you to the dialogue:

- What do I really want for myself?
- What do I really want for others?
- What do I really want for the relationship?
- How would I behave if I really wanted these results?

1. Learn to Look - How to Notice When Safety is at Risk: It can be difficult to see what exactly is going on and why during crucial conversations. Watch for these situations to learn to spot one:

- The moment a conversation turns crucial
- Signs that people feel safe
- Your own style under stress

1. Make It Safe: Nothing kills dialogue faster than fear. When you make it safe, you can talk about almost anything and people will listen. If you spot safety risks as they happen, you can step out of the conversation, build safety, and then find a way to dialogue about almost anything.

1. Master Your Stories: Learn to exert influence over your feelings by slowing down the storytelling process, take a step back, and retrace your path to action one element at a time.

These are just a few strategies outlined in the Crucial Conversation book. We highly recommend reading it for leading teams at GitLab.

How Crucial Conversations align with GitLab Values

| GitLab Value | Crucial Conversation Connection |

| ----- | ----- |

| Collaboration | Crucial conversations are introduced not just by people leaders but by all GitLab team members. We are all managers of one and should feel enabled to open crucial conversations whenever necessary. Building a shared pool of meaning in a discussion requires everyone in the conversation to share to be successful. |

| Results | Crucial conversations are results-oriented. Conversations should focus on action that will improve the situation or problem for all members involved in the conversation. |

| Efficient | Crucial conversations can be evaluated via the CPR (Content, Pattern, Relationship) method to determine the root cause of the conflict or problem. This method allows for efficiency in approaching crucial conversations with specific tools depending on the context. |

| Diversity, Inclusion, and Belonging | Everyone has a shared voice in a crucial conversation. The goal is to fill a shared pool of knowledge with facts and stories from all points of view. Hosts of crucial conversations should be open to having their stories challenged. |

| Iteration | Crucial conversations should happen early and often. The CPR (Content, Pattern, Relationship) encourages conversation early and often in the content category before something becomes a pattern |

| Transparency | Results, goals, and stories about crucial conversations are shared throughout teams to encourage more crucial conversations. While the content of specific conversations isn't always shared to maintain a safe space, the discussion about practicing crucial conversations keeps us accountable. |

Strategies for Successful Crucial Conversations

9 Influencing Strategies

The ability to influence is an essential leadership skill. To influence is to have an impact on the behaviors, attitudes, opinions and choices of your team members and others across GitLab and externally. Influence should not be confused with power or control. It is also not about manipulating others to get your own way. It is about noticing what motivates team members commitment and using that knowledge to leverage performance and results.

Leadership has sometimes been described as the ability to influence others. An effective leader does not move team members into action by coercion. An effective leader will articulate the overall vision and goals for the organization. By doing such this can motivate and move team members to action by tapping into their desires and need for success. Positive influence that is properly channeled can also bring about transformation and change for team members, department, division and the company. A leader that exhibits and exerts positive influence in others will build trust and become a true driving force towards transparency, iteration, collaboration and results.

There are many different influencing strategies and in this section we are going to review 9 that leaders can review. Each strategy below will include a definition, example and ways for leaders to develop this strategy.

1. Empowerment: Making others feel valued by involving them in decision making and giving them recognition.

- Example: Manager invites their team members to a meeting in order to take their inputs on how to improve product quality.

- Develop: Finding win-win situations, not taking people for granted, not providing unsolicited advice to people and having confidence in the ability of others.

1. Interpersonal Awareness: Being able to recognize and address the concerns of key stakeholders.

- Example: A manager/leaders offers support to team members by identifying a list of questions that may be asked in meetings with senior leadership.

- Develop: Awareness of verbal and non verbal cues, putting yourself in another person's shoes and testing your own understanding of the message.

1. Negotiating: Gaining support from others by mutually agreeing on a common set of goals or outcomes.

- Example: A vendor who is trying to land a big deal may offer their client incentives or a discount provided the size of the order large enough.

- Develop: Understand the other person's requirements, identify your non-negotiable, role-play with a colleague, practice in a low risk real life situation.

1. Networking: Establish and maintain a network of contacts who you may need to influence going forward.

- Example: A manager spends time with their peers or cross functional partners in different activities (either work or non work related) in order to develop a better bond/relationship with their network.

- Develop: Take interest in other peoples lives, find common ground, leverage existing relationships and take advantage of existing opportunities.

1. Stakeholder awareness: Identifying the key stakeholder and the ability to gain support when needed.

- Example: A manager identifies the key stakeholder and decision maker within a supporting organization and regularly meets with them to collaborate.

- Develop: Keep your ear to the ground to understand what is happening around you, learn by example, identify the decision makers, appreciate other's points of view.

1. Shared vision: Showing others how your ideas support the broader organizational vision.

- Example: A manager communicates their vision to their team by helping them understand what they can become and the steps needed to achieve the goal.

- Develop: Always keep the outcomes in sight, speak about the benefits of the approach and get others to participate.

1. Impact and Influence: Choosing the most appropriate time and manner to present your point, always keeping in mind your audience.

- Example: A manager understands the landscape or demographics of their audience and is thoughtful in their presentation approach.

- Develop: Study prominent influencers, try different approaches each time, take formal training, model good influencers within the organization.

1. Analytical reasoning: Using analytical reasoning to convince others about your point of view.

- Example: A team member uses data and market insights to convince their manager about their ideas.

- Develop: Have more than 1 reason for your idea, clearly lay out the pros and cons, show clarity of thought and structure, spend time on research and case studies.

1. Coercion: Using threats or pressure tactics to get other to agree to your point or to comply to rules.

- Example: A manager makes a decision with no or little input from team and informs team members of actions or consequences if they do not comply.

- Develop: Use it sparingly and not as the first resort, leave no room for ambiguity and do not use as a way to suppress your team member or others.

Having crucial conversations on an all-remote team

Having crucial conversations via a Zoom call might be more difficult than having the conversation in person. These strategies are meant to identify what makes having crucial conversations in an all-remote environment challenging and things we can try to make the conversations more effective.

1. Pre-populate your 1:1 meeting agenda so that everyone can come prepared to have meaningful conversations. The ability to prepare ensures that everyone in the conversation knows the topics that will be discussed and can prepare in advance.

1. In a video call, we might miss out on key body language markers that are more apparent when having conversations in person. Focus on the body language queues we can see. Does someone who typically uses video have their video off, or does someone turn their video off suddenly? Does the person seem to be looking away or looking down, avoiding the screen?

1. If an async conversation is starting to get heated and is veering away from productive dialogue, move to a synchronous call to increase safety.

1. Async conversations make it easier for us to hold off a response until emotions cool off, preventing a fight or flight response. This can be helpful in some cases but watch out for its detriments. It's important to speak up about projects or conversations that make you feel upset or unheard.

1. It's easy to assign tone to text-based communication. The tone we assign can influence the story we tell ourselves. We can avoid this by assuming positive intent. Emoji can help to add context to text-based communication.

1. Make space for pause. Silent pauses on a phone call might feel awkward or uncomfortable.

These pauses are necessary for people to process feelings and stress and craft thoughtful responses during crucial conversations. Try using these phrases if you need to create a space for silence:

- Can we wait one second before moving on to that topic?
- I need a minute to think through this one.
- Can we take a pause for a minute?
- I need a few extra seconds/minutes to think through my response here
- I think I got defensive there - let me take a second to regroup

1. If you're in a crucial conversation and a team member uses one of these phrases to indicate they need a pause, remember to respect their need for time by:

- Don't try to fill the space with more talking. Let there be a minute or two of quiet on the line.
- Let your eyes gaze around the room, down, or at your notes if you need something else to focus on
- Wait until the person you're speaking with initiates conversation again before speaking

1. Asking questions lets everyone determine what facts and stories are present in the conversation. They can be asked in a synchronous and async formats. Example questions include

- What do you think?
- Can I get your perspective/a different perspective on this?
- How do you feel?
- Can I get your feedback on...

1. During a crucial conversation, different priorities might come up from members in the conversation. It's important to determine what conversation people are prepared to participate in and what topics are most important and efficient to address. Determining the root cause of the conversation is important here. Think about questions like:

- Is this turning into a performance discussion?
- Do we need to reschedule so we can all prepare?
- Is this conversation about a specific problem?
- Has this problem happened before?
- What is the most pressing issue to address?
- Is what is pressing for me the same thing that is pressing for others in the discussion?

1. Historical messages in tools like GitLab and Slack might help you gather information about the tone and communication patterns of people you're having crucial conversations with.

1. Transparency in GitLab projects, Slack statuses, and Google Calendar gives us a picture into what projects our remote team members are working on. We can use this as a tool to help fill our own pool of meaning and have a deeper understanding for the workload that our peers have.

1. Give team members who are uncomfortable verbalizing in a group on call the option to ask someone to please verbalize. While GitLab issues and Slack may be more comfortable areas for them to contribute, decisions do get made on Zoom calls. Encourage team members to add their input in the agenda doc or Zoom comments section with please verbalize in parentheses. The lead for the call should then verbalize their input to the larger group, so it becomes part of the discussion. This can help create a safe space for their ideas to be shared.

What GitLab Managers Say about Crucial Conversations

During the Manager Challenge Program, we asked GitLab Managers what they had to say about holding crucial conversations

1. "As noted in Crucial Conversations finding that shared goal and relying on the trust in the

conversation ensures the dialogue will be non-threatening."

1. "The hardest conversations are with those who are not performing and helping them understand what they need to work on or improve upon. The joy is when they do respond and approve, which happens more than not. The other conversations is mentoring and seeing the growth from it. The joy is to see them prosperous and I've had many work for me again. Those to me are both sides of the equation."

1. "One thing that I can add to my list, letting someone go due to budget cuts. I find that difficult to inform a great performer and team player that they are being let go. Because it is human to feel that it is tied to performance. Luckily, in the end, they do find a new role quickly."

1. "We are so lucky with working async that we have the benefit of time to reflect before responding (part of "master your stories"). I took a moment to think about where things went awry and where I was responsible, so that I could own it and apologise first. The next step was to realign · we actually have the same goals overall, just different ideas about how we would get there. I reaffirmed what we had in common and asked them to contribute how they would go about things, which turned the conversation back to working towards a solution together."

1. "Something that I'd like to practice where applicable is to step out of a heated conversation and continue another time if possible. This is not to avoid the issue, and also, this won't suit every scenario but can help to reset the mind."

1. "One that has come up is with a team member that may want to branch out to another area within the company. This was a big deal for them to talk to me about, so I wanted to make sure they knew it was a safe space for them to do it. I never want to stand in someone's way of improving themselves or trying new challenges. I think my reaction of being enthusiastic as opposed to negative was very helpful in keeping the conversation flowing."

1. "Performance reviews can easily turn into crucial conversations. This is one reason why it is so important to make performance and career development a consistent topic throughout the year, and not a one-off conversation that happens cyclically."

1. "Product strategy. Sometimes you have to make the unpopular/hard call to say no to continue investing in a product area. The people involved tend to be passionate about their positions, and the outcome affects not only the people working on execution, but also the company's position in the market and the bottom line."

1. "I'm a new manager, and I started my role by doing performance reviews with the team. These very crucial conversations since I haven't been their manager for long, and I had to provide them with performance feedback and career development guidance."

Additional resources

Below are additional resources on influencing and leadership for you to review.

- What Great Leaders Know about Influence
- Influencing Skills: A Key to Leadership Success!
- Influencing Others: A Key Leadership Skill
- The 5 Key Skills of Influential Leaders Within Every Organization
- Influence and Leadership
- 5 Leadership Strategies Proven to Improve Performance on Your Team
- The 7 Best Books to Improve Influencing Skills
- 7 Ways to Build Influence in the Workplace
- The Power of Vulnerability

SECTION: leadership/effective-delegation.md

Effective Delegation

The purpose of this section is to give you the following:

- An appreciation for the importance of delegation to others as a way to manage workload and prioritize action items.
- Face any fears that you may have regarding delegating to others.
- Help you adopt an appropriate strategy to delegate the right tasks to the right people at the right time and in the right way.
- Help you develop a systematic step-by-step approach to brief team members on what you want to delegate to others.

What is delegation?

Delegation is the assignment of responsibilities to another person for the purpose of carrying out specific job-related activities. Delegation is a shift of decision-making authority from one team member to another.

Considerations when delegating

Before further diving into delegation, it's important for you as a leader to consider whether delegation is the right thing to do. In this Situational Leadership Strategy article, GitLab's co-founder Sid Sijbrandij gives an overview of 4 leadership styles discussed in Situational Leadership Theory and the factors he considers when determining whether to delegate.

Benefits of Delegation

Manager/Leader Benefits

- Reduced stress
- Improve time management
- Increased trust

Team Member Benefits

- Professional knowledge and skills development
- Enhanced self-esteem and confidence
- Sense of achievement

GitLab Benefits

- Increased teamwork and collaboration
- Increased productivity and efficiency

So why do managers struggle with delegation?

As a Manager, we have to delegate tasks and activities to achieve results. Delegation only

works when both the team member and manager share a common understanding of the problem set and how to go about solving them. If a Manager doesn't understand fully what they are delegating, achieving results could be slowed down. Delegation without follow-through by the manager is abandonment. When delegating tasks, consider monitoring the team member's progress based on their level of competence/skills with the tasks.

Additional reasons why managers struggle with delegation:

- It is too hard
- It takes too much time
- Nobody can do it as well as I can
- Nobody else has the time
- They are scared things will fail
-